Who Decides New York?

The off-year electorate, resolved by party — from 13.5 million individual registration and vote records

*Party-resolved companion to `who-decides-washington.md` and `who-decides-idaho.md` (the deep-red counterpart). Washington showed the off-year electorate is older; New York publishes each voter's party enrollment, so here we can ask the question Washington could not — whose electorate ages, who is locked out, and where the real decision is made. DRAFT — pending the independent-verification gate in `publication-checklist.md`.***

Provenance. All figures from `data/ny_vrdb.duckdb` — New York's NYSVOTER statewide file (13.54M registrants; individual party enrollment + full DOB + per-event vote history, all ~100% populated) — via `scripts/diag_ny_turnout_party.py`, `scripts/diag_ny_primary_participation.py`, and `scripts/diag_ny_electorate_extras.py`. Competitiveness from `forecast_predictions`. Each figure below traces to one of these scripts.

Load-bearing caveat. The file is the current (2026) roll, so voters who cast a past ballot but were since purged/moved are absent. Composition shares are robust; turnout rates are biased high for older cycles (and cross-party comparison within a year is valid — the bias hits every group equally). "NOPARTY" = New York's blank/no-party enrollment; its lean is never imputed.

The question

How *many* people vote is the wrong question for understanding how a state is governed. The right one is *who* — and in New York the answer changes dramatically with the calendar, because most local offices are filled in odd-year Novembers and most legislative seats are settled in low-turnout closed primaries. New York is the one large state that lets us answer "who" with the variable that matters most: **individual party of record.**

The short answer: **the people who decide New York are older than the state, and the gap is not partisan-neutral.** The off-year electorate is not a smaller copy of the presidential one — it is older, its Republican wing ages hardest, a quarter of registrants are structurally excluded from the contest that usually decides, and the rolls are quietly shifting away from both parties.

I. The off-year electorate is older — New York replicates Washington

Share of the general-election electorate by age band:

Election	Type	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+	median
Nov 2024	Presidential	**14.1%**	23.1%	34.6%	28.2%	53
Nov 2022	Midterm	9.8%	21.1%	38.5%	30.6%	56
Nov 2025	Off-year	11.5%	21.0%	33.1%	34.4%	56
Nov 2023	Off-year	**6.0%**	15.8%	36.5%	**41.6%**	61

As the contest shrinks (presidential → midterm → odd-year), the under-30 share collapses (14% → 6% by 2023) and the 65+ share swells (28% → 42%); median age rises from 53 to 61. **Behavior, not rolls.** A Das-Gupta decomposition of the 65+ share rise from 2024 to 2025 attributes it ~5–6× more to differential **turnout** than to the registration age structure (rate effect +7.5 to +8.7 pts vs composition +0.6 to +1.5, across parties) — the young *choose not to vote* off-cycle. This is an institutional, on-cycle-timing-fixable pattern, not a registration artifact.

II. Now we can see party — and the Republican electorate ages hardest

This is the cut Washington's data cannot make. Share of each party's voters who are 65+:

Election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
Nov 2024 (pres)	28.7%	32.4%	22.2%	27.0%
Nov 2025 (odd)	32.1%	**42.8%**	30.6%	35.1%

Election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
Nov 2023 (odd)	41.6%	43.5%	39.3%	37.4%

Median age within each party tells the same story — in the 2025 off-year, the **Republican median voter is 62 vs the Democratic 54**, an 8-year gap that was only ~5 years in the presidential electorate. The GOP's 65+ share jumps from 32% (presidential) to 43% (odd-year), and its under-30 participation collapses to roughly a third of the presidential level. The off-year electorate is not just older; **its Republican wing ages most.**

That New York's *Republican* wing ages hardest is itself a New York fact, not a law of nature: the deep-red companion, `who-decides-idaho.md`, finds the opposite structure — Idaho's Democratic and Republican electorates age almost identically (65+ share 31.5% vs 31.7% in 2024), and the youth that drops off in low-salience contests sits in the *unaffiliated* and minor-party blocs, not in one major party. Whose electorate ages is contingent on the state; *that* the low-salience electorate is older, and that the young who exit are the least partisan, recurs in both.

But the *composition* heuristic that "older off-year electorate ⇒ more Republican" **does not hold in deep-blue New York.** The DEM–REP share gap among actual voters is event-driven, not turnout-driven — it swings from +15.6 (2023) to +33.2 (2025) depending on what's on the ballot — and the unaffiliated, not either party, are the ones who drop out (25.5% of the roll, but only 16–22% of voters). And in even-year federal contests Republicans out-turn Democrats at *every* age, yet that discipline inverts off-cycle: in the 2025 general, Democratic under-30 turnout (30.8%) was nearly **double** Republican (15.9%). Party-resolved, the signal lives in age structure and youth mobilization, not in a simple rightward headcount shift.

III. The unaffiliated quarter: young, disengaged, and locked out

A quarter of New York registrants (25.1% of the active roll) enroll in no party. They are not high-information independents holding the balance:

	median age	%65+	%18–29	2024 turnout	donors / 1k
DEM	49	26.7%	17.3%	58.4%	33.0
REP	55	30.6%	14.0%	**69.5%**	23.6
NOPARTY	**42**	17.7%	**24.0%**	**50.4%**	**12.5**

The blank bloc is the **youngest, least likely to vote, and least likely to donate** group in the state. And under New York's **closed** primaries they are excluded by law from the contest that, in most of the state, *is* the election (§V). A quarter of registrants have no voice at the nominating stage.

IV. The nominating electorate is smaller still

New York settles most legislative seats in party primaries that only enrollees may vote in. Participation rate by enrollment:

Primary	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
2024 Presidential	4.8%	4.9%	0.1%	0.2%
2024 State/Congress	7.7%	1.7%	0.1%	0.6%
2022 State/Congress	17.9%	18.4%	0.6%	2.0%
2021 (odd-year)	16.9%	5.0%	0.5%	1.5%

Two facts: primary turnout runs from single digits to the high teens — the electorate that *nominates* is a small fraction of the one that *elects* — and the **25.3% enrolled "blank" are structurally absent** (≈0.1–0.6%, the residual being nonpartisan/special races). In blue New York the **Democratic primary is frequently the decisive contest** (2021 odd-year DEM 16.9% vs REP 5.0%; 2024 state DEM 7.7% vs REP 1.7%).

V. Safe-seat New York — where the primary is the election

The reason the primary so often decides: by registration alone, most districts are not competitive. District counts by registration lean (DEM% − REP%, active roll):

Level	Safe D (40+)	Likely D (20–40)	Lean D (5–20)	Competitive (<5)	Lean/Likely R	Safe R (20+)
Congressional (26)	9	3	7	**4**	3	0
Assembly (150)	55	31	19	**17**	21	7

Only **4 of 26 congressional and 17 of 150 Assembly districts (11%) are competitive** by registration; 19/26 and 105/150 lean Democratic. In the large majority of New York, the November general is a foregone conclusion and the real decision is thrown to the small, enrollment-gated primary electorate of §IV.

VI. A leading indicator: new registrants are abandoning party labels

The blank bloc is not a legacy artifact — it is *growing through new registration*. Party mix of each year's new registrants still on the roll:

reg year	%DEM	%REP	%NOPARTY	median age at reg
2008	57.8%	16.2%	20.7%	29
2016	51.5%	18.5%	25.6%	30
2020	40.9%	21.3%	33.7%	30
2024	**39.7%**	22.1%	**35.6%**	29

The Democratic share of new registrants has fallen ~18 points since 2008 while the no-party share has risen ~15 points (Republican roughly flat). The electorate that will decide future off-years is registering at a steady ~29–30 but is **increasingly choosing no party** — and, per §III–IV, that choice is also a choice to sit out the nominating stage. (Survivorship caveat: only registrants still on today's roll appear; read the *trend in party mix*, which is composition-based, as the robust cut.)

Boundary of inference

- **Turnout rates vs shares.** The current-roll denominator inflates turnout *rates* for older cycles; composition *shares* (§I–II) and within-year cross-party comparisons (§II–IV) are the robust cuts.
- **NOPARTY lean is never imputed.** The blank bloc's partisan sympathies are unobserved; we describe its age, turnout, and donation behavior, not its hidden preference (its federal *giving*, separately, leans ~2:1 Democratic — see `ny-donor-class-by-party.md`).
- **Vote-history formats.** NYSVOTER mixes ~6 county-specific history formats per election; the normalized parser is validated against known turnout (2024 presidential ≈ 7.4M, the credible figure for the current roll).
- **Competitiveness (§V uses registration; the safe-seat paper uses observed margins).** Registration lean is a structural proxy, not a vote result; it corroborates the observed map rather than replacing it.

What it means

New York lets us put a party label on every filter between the registered population and the decision: an older general electorate, an older-still and asymmetrically-Republican off-year electorate, a closed primary that excludes a young, disengaged quarter of the state, and a district map on which that primary is the real election almost everywhere. The reform implication is the same one Washington's data pointed to — **move local elections on-cycle** — but New York adds the evidence that the off-year distortion is not partisan-neutral and that the unaffiliated, fastest-growing slice of the electorate is precisely the slice most excluded by the current calendar and primary structure. Combined with the donor-class paper, the picture is a series of narrowing, increasingly unrepresentative gates — who registers, who votes, who votes in the primary, and who pays.

Methods & reproducibility

```
python scripts/load_ny_voters.py                        # NYSVOTER FOIL -> ny_vrdb.duckdb
python scripts/diag_ny_turnout_party.py --rebuild       # turnout by age x party (I, II)
STATE=NY python scripts/diag_ny_primary_participation.py # closed-primary participation (IV)
STATE=NY python scripts/diag_ny_electorate_extras.py     # blank bloc / decomposition / trend / safe-s
```

All inputs are public records (NY NYSVOTER under its lawful-use FOIL terms). See `data-sources-and-reproducibility.md` for the source ledger and method notes, and `ny-turnout-by-party-age.md` / `ny-electorate-extras.md` for the full underlying tables.